

HNB in Croatia's inflation debate

More attention to prices need not mean more attention to the central bank.

The paper asks whether the Croatian National Bank's (HNB) relative media visibility keeps pace when inflation dominates the news. Its contribution is to separate what the institution publishes from its place in the wider debate. Higher inflation accompanies a smaller institutional share in the primary models; visibility declines during April 2024-May 2026.

READING THE INDICATOR

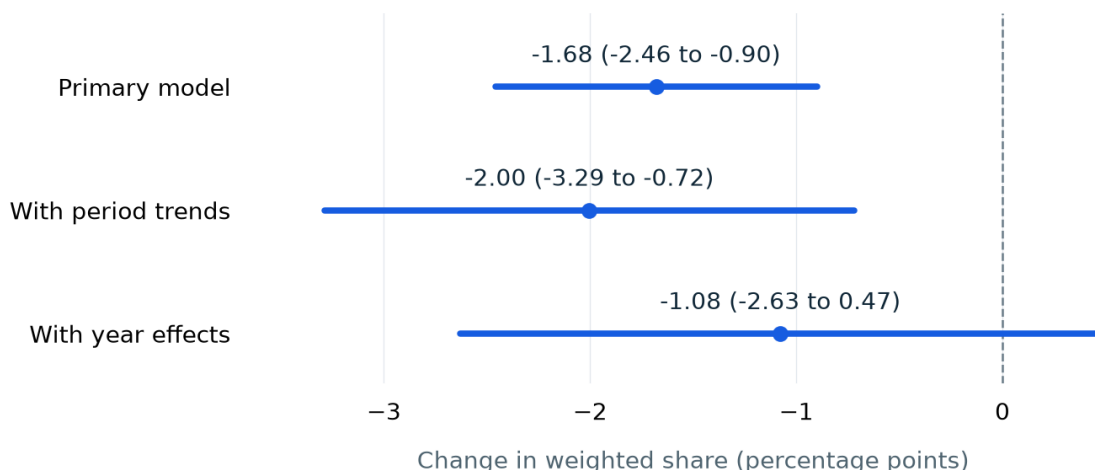
Relevance selects items about inflation. **Prominence** reflects the institution's presence in the title, position and frequency of mentions, and cues that it acts or speaks. The measure combines prominence with potential reach and compares this with reach across inflation coverage. The **attention gap = baseline share minus current weighted share**. A larger gap means less relative visibility.

Example: a 4% baseline and a 3% current share give a +1 percentage-point gap. These are illustrative values. The baseline is a historical reference, not a communication target; the share is neither readership nor a simple percentage of articles.

THE SCALE OF THE INFLATION ASSOCIATION

Inflation from 2% to 10%: a 1.68 percentage-point lower weighted share. Holding the other variables fixed, the primary weekly model implies a weighted share lower by the same amount (95% interval: 0.90 to 2.46). This is the paper's conditional comparison, not a forecast or a policy effect.

Inflation: 2% → 10%



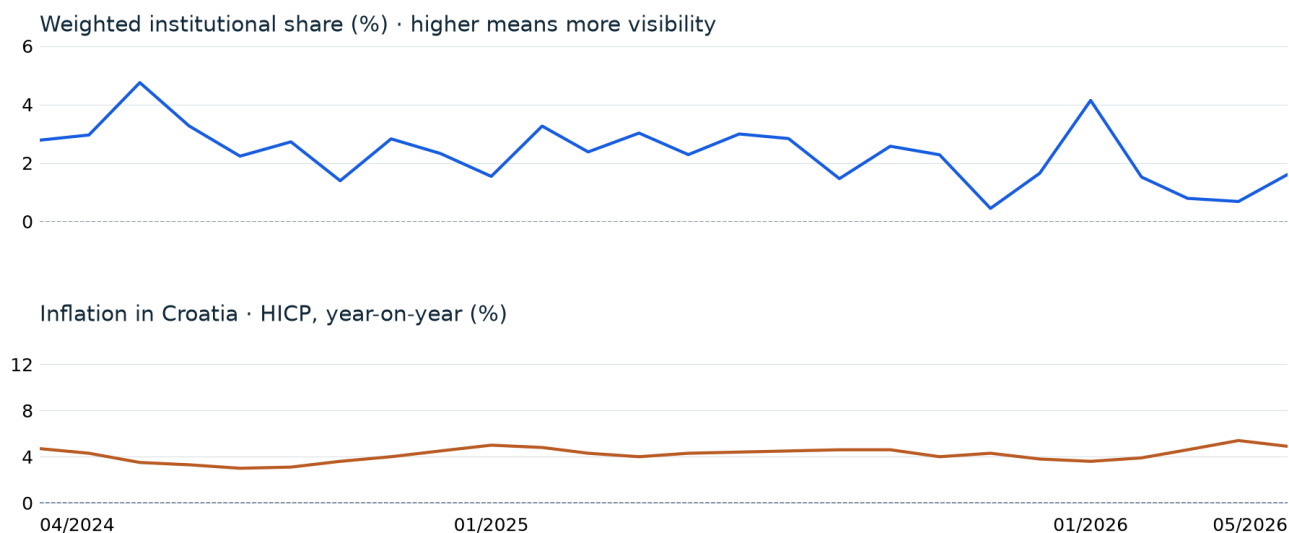
Conditional differences, other variables held fixed · 95% intervals · 268 weeks

How robust? Per 1 percentage point higher inflation, the primary gap estimate is 0.21 pp (95% interval 0.11 to 0.31; 268 fitted weeks). All three chart models include media volume. With year effects, the interval includes zero; the association is not independent of every choice of time controls. The monthly trend-control model is also inconclusive.

Source: paper Section 4.2 and Appendix A23. HICP is the Harmonised Index of Consumer Prices; inflation is the year-on-year rate.

What the findings mean for HNB

1. Assess visibility after the inflation surge as well. Within April 2024-May 2026, the controlled gap trend is +0.076 pp per month (95% interval 0.035 to 0.118; 25 fitted months). Keeping only common sources still gives +0.056 pp per month ($p = 0.045$). This is evidence of declining relative visibility within that period, not proof that disinflation caused the decline.



April 2024–May 2026 | Observed values, not a fitted trend.

Share = baseline – gap. Potential reach is not actual exposure. Source: extended draft, 17 September 2026.

2. Distinguish visibility from network position. A share describes how much of the debate the institution occupies. Centrality describes its position among actors linked through media sources, weighting connections to well-connected actors more heavily. The common-source monthly trend is -0.0051 index units (95% interval -0.0129 to 0.0027; $p = 0.187$). The interval includes zero: lasting structural erosion is not established.

3. Read media evidence alongside expectations surveys. For the article-share measure, baseline weekly projections find no significant future horizons with linear survey interpolation, but weeks 1-2 with step assignment; the monthly comparison finds month 12, after correction for multiple tests. Controls change the pattern too. These results do not establish a stable predictive channel, or show that a media gap causes expectations to become unanchored.

Implication for the governor. Consider institutional output, relative media representation and public understanding as separate dimensions. More publications need not produce a larger share of a growing debate. The gap adds a diagnostic of representation; it does not score message quality, credibility or policy success.

SCOPE AND SOURCE

January 2021-May 2026: 60 monthly / 268 weekly observations in the main regressions. Generic central-bank terms may include the ECB or others; potential reach is not observed exposure. The selected corpus is not a representative audience sample. Earlier-paper numerical discrepancies remain unresolved. Jan-Mar 2024 media values are missing; April 2024 marks a collection change. Levels across the boundary are not harmonized.

Petra Palić and Luka Sikić | Hrvatsko katoličko sveučilište. Independent draft, 17 September 2026; not an HNB publication. Sections 4.2-4.7, discussion, Appendices A12, A23 and B2. Figures and numbers use saved results; models were not re-estimated.

[Research page and interactive evidence](#)